BBC Report

Documentary about

The 59-minute film examines the Gujarat riots of 2002, which were among the deadliest acts of religious violence in India since that country's independence in 1947. It describes how riots broke out when 59 people were killed when a train carrying Hindu pilgrims in the northern state of Gujarat was set on fire. Following the incident, revenge attacks claimed the lives of over 1,000 individuals, the majority of whom were Muslims, and the Muslim community was held accountable.

Modi had only been Gujarat's chief minister for a little under five months at the time. His detractors deem his decision to permit the bodies of those who perished on the train to be transported to Ahmedabad, the state's capital, offensive. Horrific acts of violence followed, including the systematic burning of Muslim homes and the rape of Muslim women by mobs. In front of his house, a former member of parliament was slain. The BBC documentary holds Modi accountable, citing a covert inquiry by British diplomats that found Modi to be "personally responsible" for the "environment of impunity."

The BBC programme uses archive material and interviews with Indian academics and riot survivors, but probably the most important interview is with Jack Straw, who served as Britain's foreign secretary during the riots. He claims that the British High Commission in India looked into the violence on its own. The U.K. government was informed in its assessment that the level of violence was "far more than reported" and was intended to "purge Muslims from Hindu communities." The research came to the conclusion that there were much more fatalities than the official figure of 1,044 deaths, that the police were instructed not to intervene, and that Modi was "undoubtedly" to blame for the violence.

A BBC interview with Modi that took place shortly after the rioting is also shown in the programme. Modi says he needs to learn how to deal with the media when questioned about the lessons he has learned. He has paid attention to that: Since becoming prime minister, Modi has shunned all media attention and hasn't given a single spontaneous press conference. His interactions with Muslims as prime minister are covered in the second half of the show. Muslims now have it harder in Modi's India.

The second, hour-long installment, which was released on January 24, 2023, looks at Modi's administration's actions after his 2019 reelection. It looks at several contentious policies, like as the new citizenship law and the removal of Kashmir's autonomy. It features interviews with the relatives of those killed in the 2020 Delhi riots and exposes the deadly response of security personnel to demonstrations against the new legislation.

Background check

The 2002 Gujarat riots, sometimes referred to as the Gujarat violence, were a three-day intercommunal conflict in the Gujarat state in western India. The violence is attributed to the fire of a train in Godhra on February 27, 2002, which resulted in the deaths of 58 Hindu pilgrims and karsevaks returning from Ayodhya. Following the original riot occurrences, there were additional violent outbursts in Ahmedabad for three months, as well as across the state of Gujarat against the minority Muslim population over the next year.

Official statistics show that 1,044 people died in the riots, 223 are still missing, and 2,500 were injured. 254 Hindus and 790 Muslims were among the deceased. According to the Concerned Citizens Tribunal Report, as many as 1,926 people may have died. According to other sources, there were more than 2,000 fatalities. There have been several reports of savage murders, rapes, and widespread looting and property damage. Police and government officials who allegedly guided the rioters and handed them lists of Muslim-owned houses, as well as Narendra Modi, then the Chief Minister of Gujarat and eventually the Prime Minister of India, were accused of supporting the violence.

On February 27, 2002, at 7:42 a.m., the Sabarmati Express arrived at Godhra's station. The travellers included karsevaks leaving towards Ayodhya. They allegedly got into a confrontation with some Muslim tea vendors on the Godhra station. Someone pulled the emergency brake cord as the train accelerated away from the predominantly Muslim neighbourhood.

It appears that at this point, a Muslim crowd attacked the train. 58 passengers were killed in two carriage fires, most of whom were allegedly karsevaks, but subsequent reports contradicted this.

In Gujarat, the incident led to seven-day long statewide rioting that resulted in over 1,000 fatalities and over a lakh people living in refugee houses. Muslim victims predominated, while Hindu attackers did the attacking. Since Partition, it is regarded as India's worst riot.

The BJP was performing poorly in Gujarat's electoral politics at the time. It had lost three byelections for the Assembly as well as the gramme panchayat elections in 2001. Keshubhai Patel, the longtime BJP warhorse, has been abruptly replaced by Narendra Modi in October 2001.

The Supreme Court established a special investigative team (SIT) in 2008 following the unabated violence that continued for around three days before the army troops intervened and brought the situation under control. The violence in Naroda Patiya, Naroda Gaam, and the Gulbarg Society case were among the nine significant cases that the SIT investigated.

Nonetheless, reports of intercommunal violence came from various sections of the state throughout the following three to four months.

Almost 150 of the 600 people who were accused in the 12 key Godhra and post-Godhra riots cases have been given life sentences after being found guilty in close to 200 of the cases. They consist of the nine post-Godhra cases that the Supreme Court-appointed SIT (Special Investigation Team) ordered to be reinvestigated, the Godhra train fire case, and the Bilkis Banu and Best Bakery cases.

How did India respond

The Modi administration swiftly and unequivocally condemned the action. A representative for the foreign ministry claimed during the weekly news conference that the BBC's "bias, lack of neutrality, and basically ongoing colonial attitude are obviously visible" and that it was working against the government. Shortly after, the authorities used emergency legislation to prohibit the online distribution of links and video samples from the documentary, and Twitter and YouTube cooperated. Throughout the past year, the law has been used to prohibit internet content that is critical of the government, but this is the most prominent instance.

Several BJP politicians charged the BBC with having an anti-Modi agenda by reviving claims that were made two decades prior and were later rejected by the courts. The supreme court rejected a plea that asked for the BBC to be prohibited from functioning in India. India is forbidden: Independent critics, human rights organisations, and opposition parties have all referred to the Modi Question as an attack on journalistic freedom. Leaders of the Trinamool Congress, Derek O'Brien and Mahua Moitra, criticised the action as censorship while tweeting links to the documentary's video. According to The Guardian, India's press freedom was curtailed at the time the documentary was banned, and there was persecution of journalists by the government and the judiciary.

According to Human Rights Watch (HRW), the ban was an example of the harsh treatment of religious minorities under Modi's administration. HRW stated that the government under Modi had often used "draconian" laws to silence critics of the government. Slate described the ban as an example of "pervasive" hostility to freedom of the press and censorship of criticism. In response to the first part of the documentary, more than three hundred Indian former judges, bureaucrats, and soldiers released a statement which criticised the BBC for "unrelenting hostility" towards India More than five hundred Indian scholars signed a petition criticising the ban, stating that it "violates our rights, as Indians, to access and discuss important information about our society and government".

The ban was cited as the most recent instance of Modi's repression of press freedom in a New York Times editorial. The Income Revenue Agency of India conducted raids of the BBC's offices in Mumbai and New Delhi in February 2023. On February 14, the searches got under way. They lasted for three days. Employees' phones and laptops were combed through. The Editors Guild of India, a non-profit organisation of journalists advocating press freedom, Amnesty International India, and opposition parties also denounced the searches, which were perceived by commentators as reprisal for the documentary. The raids by the Indian tax department "had all the appearance of retaliation," according to Reporters Without Borders, which criticised the Modi administration's efforts.

More than 300 former judges, government officials, and other notable individuals also criticised the documentary in a united statement, accusing the BBC of promoting a British colonial agenda and "putting itself up as both judge and jury to reignite Hindu-Muslim tensions." It was also brought up in the UK parliament, where Labour MP Imran Hussain pressed Prime Minister Rishi Sunak on whether the British government was aware of Modi's involvement in the unrest. Sunak retorted, "I'm not sure I agree at all with the portrayal.

In accordance with legislation set to be enacted in 2021 that permits the "blocking of information in event of emergency," India's ministry of information and broadcasting issued instructions over the weekend prohibiting any clips from the episode from being shared. Modi's current position was propelled by the events of 2002, but according to Bal, the prime minister is still very concerned about his reputation abroad and wants to be regarded as a statesman. But Bal's harshest critics will only be satisfied by a "ham-handed" crackdown on this documentary.

Why are India crying about it

The documentary comes at a highly sensitive time for India in terms of its placement on the world stage. It is currently hosting the G20, presenting itself as the "mother of democracy". As the world's second – now likely first –

largest country, with an economy bigger than the UK's, Modi is increasingly being courted by western powers on questions of geopolitics and the environment, and his growing international prominence is a vote winner at home.

Although the US, UK, and Europe have recently been accused of turning a blind eye to alleged past atrocities and current discrimination against minorities as they forge trade agreements and close alliances with India, the BBC documentary highlights these alleged violations, which may complicate these alliances in the future.

There have been many claims made in India that former colonial powers in the west are trying to undermine India's significance by bringing up old accusations because they are uneasy about its ascent.

India will have a general election next year. Though most expect Modi to win because of his vast popularity – in particular among the Hindu majority who make up 80% of the population – it is still a critical moment for the government. According to Kenneth Roth, the former executive director of the NGO Human Rights Watch, Gujarat has always been one of the most sensitive issues for Modi because he demonstrated "passivity in the face of large-scale ethnic violence." But, Roth adds, Modi shows intolerance towards a range of criticism due to fear of reputational harm, and his reaction to this documentary is no different. Have generated controversy for decades, but the BBC documentary goes a step further in highlighting his role through expert commentary — it reveals that a previously unpublished report from the British Foreign Office held Modi "directly responsible" for the "climate of impunity" that enabled the violence and said it had "all the hallmarks of an ethnic cleansing." The BBC also uncovers other memos by the British government and Western diplomats, including the former British Foreign Secretary, Jack Straw, who unequivocally criticises Modi's conduct at the time.

Interviews with former BJP politicians who support Modi and vehemently reject his involvement in the violence are also included in the documentary. They highlight the 2013 ruling of the Indian Supreme Court, which held that there wasn't enough evidence to charge him.

Foreign Views

British Prime Minister Rishi Sunak, whose family originated in pre-Partition India, is currently in a difficult situation. With a trade agreement that he thinks will show that the United Kingdom can negotiate trade terms with other countries that are superior to those permitted by the European Union, he wants to deepen ties with India. A settlement is not assured, though, in part because no British government is willing to give India what it wants: additional visas for students and corporate leaders, together with the ability to remain longer. In addition, India is not about to provide British companies access to its legal or financial services industries, as the U.K. demands.

According to ANI, a representative for Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov claimed that the UK broadcaster was waging an information war not just against Russia but also against other nations with autonomous foreign policies. The spokesperson stated, "I would like to bring your attention to the fact that it is yet another example of the BBC waging an information war on numerous fronts - not just against Russia, but also against other global centres of power pursuing an independent agenda.

"After a certain number of years, it becomes apparent that the BBC is engaged in conflict even within the British establishment, serving as a weapon for some groups' interests against those of others. That needs to be handled appropriately,"said the representative.

The United States had said that it supports the need of a free press around the world and made it a point in India as well. US State Department spokesperson Ned Price replied to a query by a Pakistani journalist on the documentary, "I'll say generally, when it comes to this, we support the importance of a free press around the world," Price replied.

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